The Surajkund Crafts Mela began with a flourish in the mid-'80s. Crafts took a leap forward in the consciousness of the moneyed elite, who were put off by low-quality industrial goods by foreign brands in the 1990s. An interesting point is that far from being overshadowed by global brands, the uniqueness, diversity and kaleidoscopic nature of India's crafts offered an attractive contrast. At the ground level, India's diverse cultural practices kept local production alive.

At the risk of sounding immodest, the concept of the 'Urban Haat', introduced by me in 1994 through the establishment of Dilli Haat in the capital city gave an impetus to the idea of a permanent crafts market dedicated exclusively to craftspeople, so that they can sell their works without middlemen. Direct interaction with high-end as well as simple, middle-class city folk helped them flourish and attain recognition. The presence of crafts in such places also began to benefit trade and tourism.

General awareness about the appeal of crafts grew among government agencies as well as NGOs, designers and online managers, with a fresh emphasis on the protection of livelihoods. The culture and foreign affairs ministries made space for crafts instead of limiting it to the textile ministry.

During tough times, which were not rare, targeted relief was provided for the rehabilitation of craft communities, for example, after natural disasters such as the mega earthquake in Gujarat and the supercyclone in Odisha.

The Covid-19 pandemic deserves special mention here. The resilience of craftspeople is a lesson for everyone. While some weavers shared raw material with others and made masks for police, bank and railway personnel, craftsmen in Kutch shared produce from their fields with those running short of rations. A batik artist in West Bengal and his workers grew vegetables on his empty plot and distributed them in the neighbourhood. Traditional artists painted their old-style figures wearing masks, washing hands and using sanitiser, apart from making masks in hundreds for sale online through NGOs. Our organisation even managed to export them to London and Singapore. After the pandemic, the enthusiasm in the market for crafts at real-life bazaars was akin to water rushing through open floodgates. Dark clouds seemed to have lifted, and no one spoke of hardships. It was like a bad dream, best forgotten.

Over the past five years, collaborations with private entities such as architects, interior designers, graphic designers, book illustrators and photographers have widened the scope for India's handicrafts, made even more accessible now through technology, internet and social media.

Generational skills, determined salesmanship, resilience and the ability to innovate and stay relevant have given crafts renewed life and vigour by attracting government attention and private entrepreneurs alike. India's craftspeople must be given the greatest credit for this renaissance. ■

IN STEP WITH THE TIMES

- The first government of India recognised the importance of the crafts sector and accorded it generous funds
- National and state awards were instituted for craftspeople, and later, Padma Shri and Shilp Guru awards were given as well
- Craft trade fairs and tourism-oriented melas promoted international trade
- Design development and display got special attention to encourage competition in the face of branded imports
- The concept of 'Haats' helped link craftspeople directly to customers
- Private craft bazaars and government trade fairs held abroad gave crafts a wider marketing platform
- Design inputs from institutions like the National Institute of Design and the National Institute of Fashion Technology, as well as private design institutes later, helped the sector stay abreast of the latest trends
- The arrival of social media and e-commerce websites, from Amazon to 'boutique sites' dedicated to the promotion and marketing of crafts, has helped the sector expand. The government, too, has set up online marketing facilities
- Government buildings, private architects, interior designers, book illustrators, hotels and regional tourist resorts have incorporated crafts in their work, thus expanding the sector's scope

In the '90s, as low-quality, mass-produced goods flooded Indian stores, crafts took a leap forward in the consciousness of the moneyed elite